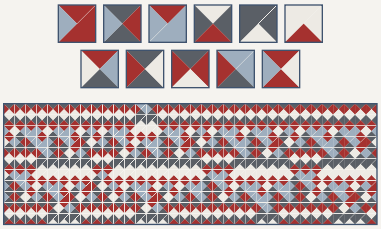
COMPUTING WITH TILES

Wang tiles that add, and a wall that counts in Fibonacci numbers

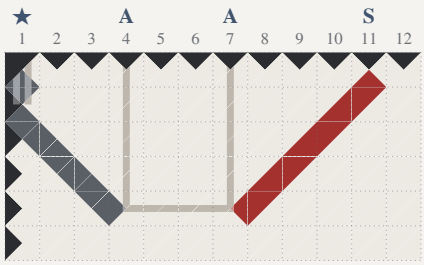
I. WANG TILES

A *Wang tiling* is a tiling of square tiles with labels on each edge, such that the labels on touching edges match. Tiles may not be rotated or reflected. We represent labels as a combination of color and etched lines, which must form a continuous line on a uniform background where edges meet. Hao Wang (王浩)[†] conjectured in 1961 that any set of such tiles that can cover the plane can also cover it periodically. Robert Berger (1966) showed otherwise: tiles can mimic any computer program (they are *Turing complete*), so whether a set tiles the plane is undecidable. Along the way he found the first *aperiodic* set, 20,426 tiles that tile the plane but never repeat. At right is the smallest aperiodic set possible: 11 tiles with 4 unique edge labels (Jeandel & Rao, 2015). Our goal is to achieve an aperiodic tiling for the home using tiles in easily obtainable practical shapes. Wang tiles are attractive because the aperiodicity is from edge matching rather than shape. The Jeandel & Rao tile set thus achieves our goal.



a minimal aperiodic set, and a patch of its tiling

II. TILES THAT ADD



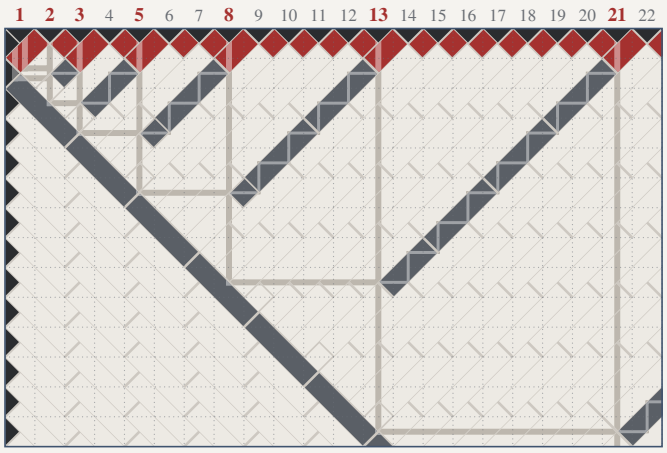
A at 4 and 7 force S to 11



This set of 16 tiles with 6 labels demonstrates one way in which Wang tiles can do arithmetic. We will work on a quarter plane whose top and left edges are constrained to be black. Place the **A** tiles on the top row at your input values, A_1 and A_2. The ★ tile can only be placed in the corner. The constraints cause an etched line to descend from each **A**. A charcoal diagonal leaves ★ at 45°; where it meets the first line it turns and starts a horizontal line at a depth corresponding to A_1. When it meets the second line a red diagonal climbs back from there. The climb reaches the top and forces the **S** tile, representing the sum, to be placed at column $A_1 + A_2$.

III. FIBONACCI NUMBERS





as it could be laid in 2″ × 8″ subway tile

By extending the adding tiles we can generate the Fibonacci numbers, since each is the sum of the two before. The tiling is aperiodic because the Fibonacci numbers spread ever further apart, so this is another way of achieving our goal. This set of 18 tiles have 9 distinct edge labels. With the top and left edges constrained to be black they fill the quarter plane in exactly one way. The **F′** and **F″** tiles in the corner mark the first two numbers, 1 and 2. Every **F** sends an etched line down. A long charcoal diagonal leaves the corner at 45°, and where it meets the line of the **F** at column n, at depth n, the line turns and runs right to the descending line of the next **F**, at column m. There a charcoal staircase climbs back at 45°, rising n rows as it moves n columns right, and reaches the top at column $m + n$: the next **F**, which then sends its own ray down.

F′ and **F″** fix the start: add two tiles that let **F″** stand at column 3 instead, and the same machinery produces the Lucas numbers 1, 3, 4, 7, 11, 18, 29.

[†] In Cantonese, Wang's surname 王 is a homophone of 黃, Wong: a name held by several members of this home.

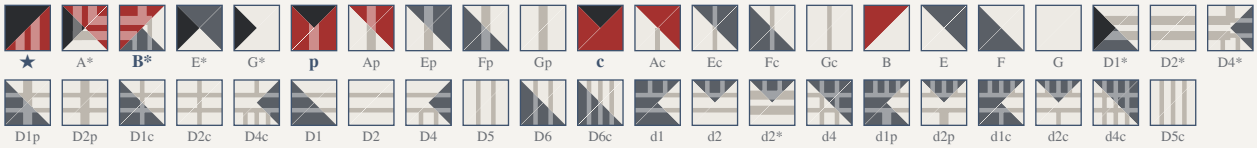
Addition and Fibonacci tiles after Grünbaum & Shephard, Tilings and Patterns, §11.4.

C. Scott Ananian · October 2026

A WALL THAT FINDS PRIMES

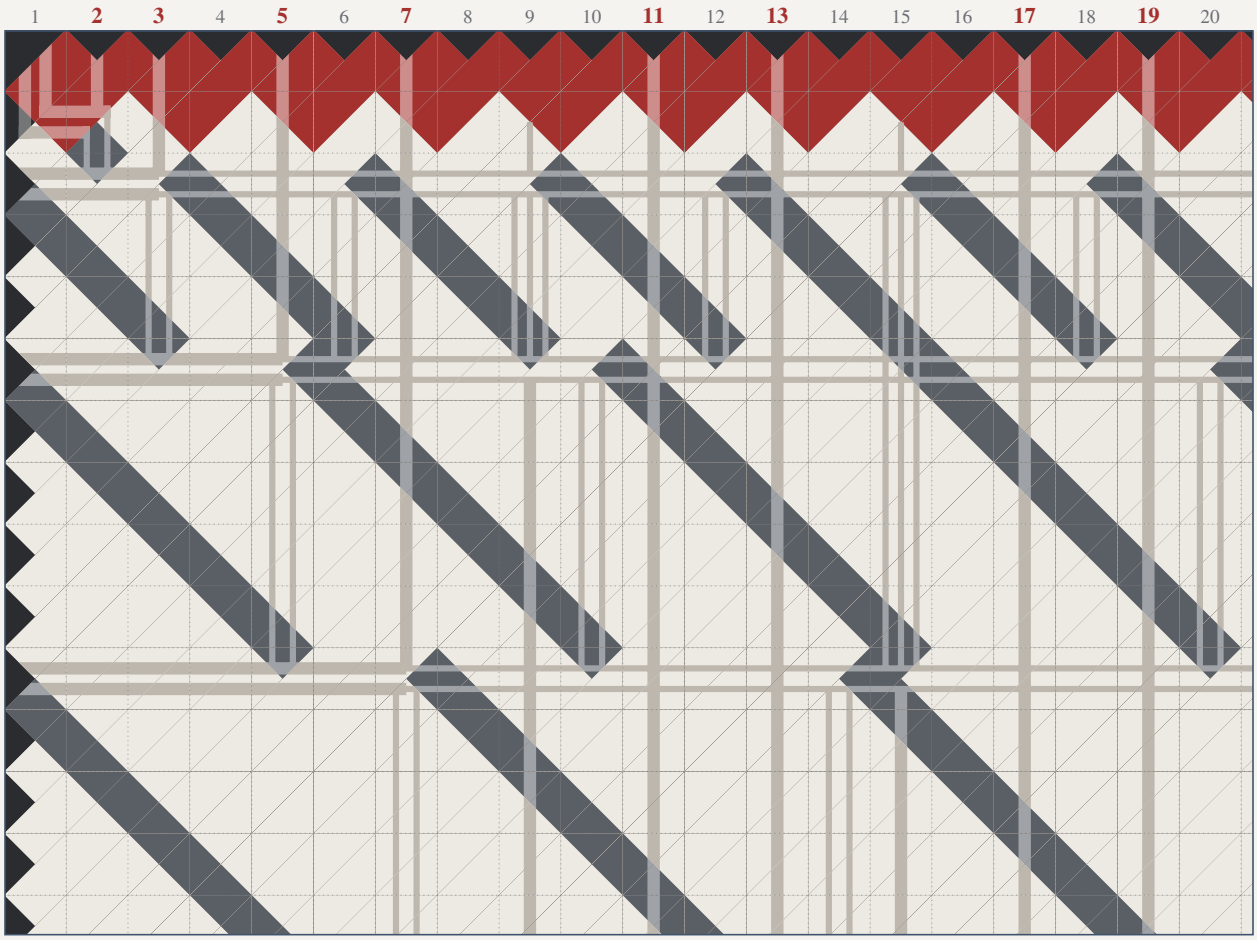
Wang tiles that sieve for primes, in ordinary 2″ × 8″ subway tile

IV. A PRIME NUMBER SIEVE



The wall in this room is an aperiodic tiling with a set of 43 Wang tiles with 15 distinct edge labels. Each edge label is shown by a tile color plus a pattern of etched lines, and a run of matching colors is laid as a single subway tile set on the diagonal. Tiles can not be rotated or reflected, edges must match, and the top and left borders must be black. Given these constraints, the tiles fill the infinite quarter plane in exactly one way, and that tiling is aperiodic due to the nature of primes.

Column *n* stands for the number *n*. The double etched lines and charcoal diagonals create rows of square boxes with odd sides, repeating across the wall and growing going down: 3, 5, 7, 9, …. The first box in each row, drawn with thick double lines, sends a thick single line up toward the top. If the line reaches the top without hitting the vertical edge of a box above it, it marks a prime; if it hits an edge, it turns into a thin line marking a composite. (Even numbers get no ray; 2 has a tile of its own, **B***.) The thick rays reach the red top row at 2, 3, 5, 7, 11, 13, 17 and 19, marked by tile **p**. Composite numbers use tile **c**.



the Wang tiling of the wall: columns 1–20, top 15 rows

Tile set PRIME2b from github.com/cscott/tile-hack (wangprime.js).

C. Scott Ananian · February 2019